

Grade 6
Volume 1
SST – History
Lesson 4 – The Earliest Societies

I. Hunting and Gathering As a Way of Life

Almost 4.6 billion years old - our Earth

About 3.5 billion years ago - life started evolving on the planet.

Earliest life forms were microorganisms, which later went on to evolve into plants, animals, and humans.

1. Who were the early humans?

Early humans were nomads.

Hunter-gatherers.

Depended on the natural environment for shelter.

Some groups lived in -

- > Caves and
- > Rock shelters

People who lived in

- Plains or in
- Desert areas

May have shelters out of

- > Branches
- > Plant fibers or
- > Animal skin

Migration

The movement of humans from one place to another.

Always formed **bands**.

Consist of –

Small and several families.

Q. How were communities formed?

Ans. When bands joined and moved together.

2. Why did the early humans migrate?

Ans.

- a. In case of natural disaster.
- b. In search of food.
- c. In search of water.

3. Qualities of the early humans

Ans.

	Skills and Qualities	Required for
a.	<i>Sharp, quick, and alert</i>	Helped in hunting
b.	<i>Smart</i>	Helped in identifying fruits and vegetables which were ➔ Edible ➔ Poisonous
c.	<i>Great memory</i>	Helped become familiar with different geographical features

II. Introduction to Stone Tools and Their Uses

The Prehistoric Era

Time before humans developed writing.

Discovery of tools made of stones.

1. How did we find out about our past?

Based on the discovery of

- Artefacts
- Metals
- Fire
- Cave paintings

The Prehistoric Era is divided into three main categories:

- *Stone Age*
- *Bronze Age*
- *Iron Age*

2. The Stone Age

Early humans first started using stones for making tools and weapons.

Helped them to

- > Hunt
- > Build shelters
- > Made life easier

Archaeologists studied Artefacts to determine when and where the Stone Age started.

Findings -

Stone Age did not begin at the same time in all places on the Earth.

The Stone Age

Divided into three distinct periods:

Palaeolithic Age – Old Stone Age

Mesolithic Age – Middle Stone Age

Neolithic Age – New Stone Age

	THE STONE AGE		
AGE	Palaeolithic Age (Old Stone Age)	Mesolithic Age (Middle Stone Age)	Neolithic Age (New Stone Age)
Time Period	Around 500000 BCE – 10000 BCE	Around 10000 BCE – 8000 BCE	Around 8000 BCE – 4000 BCE
Word Meaning	<i>palaeo</i> - old <i>lithic</i> - stone	<i>meso</i> – Middle lithic - stone	<i>neo</i> – New Lithic - stone
More Points	Around this time languages developed. People began to express themselves through art by painting the walls of caves.	Dogs were first domesticated during this period.	Transition time between the beginning of farming and the Bronze Age . People started domesticating - Cows and - Sheep

Early humans	Man - a hunter-gatherer	Continued to engage in hunting and gathering. Learnt to observe many things. How <u>new plants sprouted from seeds</u> led the early humans to settle down in one place. Took up - Agriculture - Farming	Moved less Stayed more in permanent settlements. Were mostly ➔ Farmers ➔ Herders Practised - Agriculture - Domesticated animals.
Climatic conditions	Cold climate Most parts of the world covered with ice and glaciers.	Became warmer Led to appearance of newer species of - Plants - Animals <u>Rise in the sea level</u> Due to rapid melting of ice.	End of Ice Age Climate became warmer More favourable for - Humans and - Animals
Uses of Stone Tools	Hand axes for -> Cutting and -> Chopping	Became - Sharper - Smaller Known as - Microliths included ➔ Razors ➔ Flakes ➔ Blades etc.	Became - Finer - Sharper Designed with handles Like ➔ Ploughs ➔ Sickles ➔ Axes Purpose – farming

3. Other important discoveries of the Stone Age.

-> Fire

-> Wheel

III. Archaeological Evidences of the Stone Age

1. Settlement

Neolithic period – well-structured homes

Huts –

➔ Initially made of logs and stones

➔ Later of bricks

Discovered hearths

2. Tools

Operating tools made out of polished stones.

3. Agriculture

Food needs of the early humans were fulfilled by agriculture.

Rice, wheat and lentils – major portion of diet.

Domesticated animals.

Animals also assisted in the farming activities and moving from one place to another

- Goods and
- People

4. Pottery

Pots made from clay.

Archaeologists unearthed shards of clay pots.

Early humans made pots from clay by making a hole into it,
And then finished it on the potter's wheel.

Pots of different

- Shapes and
- Sizes

Used for

- Cooking and
- Eating food

5. Religious customs

Worshipped the different powers and forces of nature.

Stone Age people *worshipped goddesses **along with** male gods.*

Evidence – Some caves show paintings of gods and goddesses and figurines.

6. Burials

The dead also continued to be revered and worshipped.

South India –

Different burial sites have been found.

Marked by rectangular blocks of stones.

Known as – megaliths (Greek - meaning 'great stones').

IV. Implications of Farming and Herding

1. The changing life

The Earth's climate became warmer towards the end of the Palaeolithic and Mesolithic periods.

The climate change was responsible for changing the lifestyle of early humans

From hunters and gatherers

To farmers and herders

Ice melted and grasslands appeared.

They started farming and domesticating animals.

They became food producers instead of food gatherers.

2. The beginning of farming and herding

Farming required time, care, and protection.

People began to settle permanently in one place.

Settled life helped them:

- Grow crops.
- Protect crops from animals and birds.
- Produce more food.

The first farmers produced the earliest crops

- Barley and
- Wheat

Hunting became less important.

Realised the advantages of having a constant water supply.

People settled near rivers and streams for water.

Water was used for:

- Drinking
- Irrigation

3. Domestication and herding of animals

Domestication - The process of taming wild animals for human use.

During the Neolithic Age, people domesticated animals.

Domestication means taming wild animals for human use.

The first domesticated animals were:

- Dogs
- Sheep
- Goats

Advantages of Domestication

- a. Dogs protected humans from danger.
 - b. Goats and sheep provided wool and meat.
 - c. Cows gave milk.
- Oxen were used for transportation.